Joan

By Robert Mauro

JOAN: So I am to die tomorrow?

PRIEST: Yes. I fear it has been decided.

JOAN: I should have guessed it would be.

PRIEST: It is God's will.

JOAN: Don't blame it on God. Everybody blames everything on him.

PRIEST: *(Turning to face her)* Are you saying then it is not God's will?

JOAN: It is more likely the wishes of men.

PRIEST: Who speak for God.

JOAN: Who at least presume to.

PRIEST: *(At a loss for words)* As you say.

INTRODUCTION

PRIEST: *History has had its fair share of monumental heroines.*
JOAN: *From Queen Elizabeth to Hilary Clinton.*
PRIEST: *Harriet Tubman to Emilia Earhart,*
JOAN: *Catwoman to Britney Spears.*
PRIEST: *And of course, who could forget Joan of Arc? (gestures to Joan who curtsies)*
JOAN: *Why, thank you.*
PRIEST: *And I get to hear all of this cross-dressing barbecued soldier's thoughts in*
BOTH: *"Joan" by* _____

JOAN is sitting in one chair. A long chain runs from the wall to her leg. The PRIEST stands with his back to JOAN. His hands are folded in prayer.

JOAN: *(After a pause)* Father?

PRIEST: Yes, Joan?

JOAN: Does it hurt to be burned at the stake?

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PRIEST: *(Turning away from her)* Joan, must we talk of that?

JOAN: *(She shrugs.)* I was just curious. Will I suffer much? Or will I just-

PRIEST: *(Turning towards her)* Must we talk of this?

JOAN: I was just curious. OK? I've never been burned at the stake before.

PRIEST: Can we speak of more pleasant things?

JOAN: Such as?

PRIEST: The weather.

JOAN: *(Laughing)* The. . . weather?

PRIEST: It is a lovely day.

JOAN: Yes? Really? *(She goes to Stage Left and stands on her tiptoes.)* I cannot see out my only window. What month is it?

PRIEST: It is May.

JOAN: *(Still stretching, trying to look out the high window)* Oh, wait. I can see the sky. It does look quite blue.

PRIEST: A glorious day. You should hear the birds singing.

JOAN: *(She stands with her arms folded.)* I fear I'll be hearing plenty of doves quite soon. *(She shivers.)*

PRIEST: Are you cold, Joan? *(He goes to give her his cloak.)*

JOAN: As death. *(He stops and she goes to sit down.)* It is damp and cold in here. And there are no birds singing.

PRIEST: I fear not. *(He sits on a chair on the other side of the table.)* Do you wish to confess your sins?

JOAN: I'd rather talk about the weather.

PRIEST: Ah, yes. Well, it is-

JOAN: *(Finishing for him)* A glorious day.

PRIEST: Truly.

JOAN: I used to love playing in the leaves when I was a little girl. Every autumn we'd

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rake them into great piles. Then run across the meadow and jump into them. It was. . . glorious.

PRIEST: Yes.

JOAN: Did you play in the leaves when you were a little child, Father?

PRIEST: *(He thinks.)* I imagine so. But it was so long ago. Still. . . I imagine I did. I and my brothers and sisters.

JOAN: Were there many?

PRIEST: Leaves?

JOAN: No. Brothers and sisters.

PRIEST: Ah, indeed. Eight.

JOAN: Eight. Really? I have three brothers and one sister.

PRIEST: All soldiers?

JOAN: No.

PRIEST: What are their names?

JOAN: There is Jacquemin, Pierre, Jean and my sister Catherine. Catherine died as a child. What are the names of your brothers and sisters?

PRIEST: There is Jacque, Peter, Christopher, Marie, Jacqueline, Noel, Daniel and myself.

JOAN: A large family is so nice.

PRIEST: Except when we fought over the milk and the bread, as children will.

JOAN: Yes. So where are they now? Are there any more priests in the family?

PRIEST: No. Just me. But my sister Jacqueline is a nun.

JOAN: Ah. Your mother and father must be proud.

PRIEST: I guess.

JOAN: What? They are not?

PRIEST: They seem happier with my brothers who are soldiers.

JOAN: Soldiers? You mean like me? *(He nods.)* Really?

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PRIEST: *(He nods.)* Yes. *(Whispering to her)* My mother thinks you are wonderful.

JOAN: God bless all our mothers.

PRIEST: *(Blessing himself)* Truly.

JOAN: And your father, Father? What does he think?

PRIEST: *(He stands and walks to Stage Front and faces audience.)* Not so wonderful.

JOAN: I see. Well, I am young. I admit to being unliked.

PRIEST: He says all women should-

JOAN: *(Finishing for him)* Have eight children, preferably all soldiers?

PRIEST: *(Pointing at her)* Amazing! How did you guess?

JOAN: When you're nineteen years old and about to be burned at the stake for wearing men's clothes, it isn't difficult.

PRIEST: Yes. Well, I fear you will not go to your final reward unless you confess. And dress as a woman.

JOAN: I dress as the soldier I am.

PRIEST: Then you will not confess?

JOAN: Confess what? That I fought for what I thought was best for my country? That I led my men as best I could for the glory of France and God? I will confess that. But I fear that is not the confession you are looking for.

PRIEST: No.

JOAN: As a result, I fear I will still be burned. Have they decided on a time yet?

PRIEST: *(Shrugs)* They don't tell me those things. It's just, "Father, go hear the prisoner's confession." Or, "Father, do this." Or, "Father, do that." I'm never told anything about the executions.

JOAN: Have there been many.

PRIEST: You'd be surprised.

JOAN: I sort of doubt that. So they don't tell you much either?

PRIEST: No. All they tell me is to pray. It's not a very demanding career.

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JOAN: Well, Father... *(Walks over to him, patting him on the back)* I'm sure it's not easy listening to the confessions of those who are about to be barbequed. I guess most are pretty upset about the whole thing.

PRIEST: To say the least. It seems these days no one is in a hurry to go to their final reward.

JOAN: Why would they be with such glorious weather?

PRIEST: This is true. Perhaps if it rained a bit more often.

JOAN: Yes, perhaps. But then God does move in mysterious ways.

PRIEST: This is true.

JOAN: Still, rain would at least make it seem all the more apropos.

PRIEST: Perhaps.

JOAN: Nevertheless, I sort of doubt that, too. One is never in a rush for the ax or the stake - rain or shine.

PRIEST: I would imagine so.

JOAN: *(She sits.)* Take it from one who knows first hand. They are not.

PRIEST: Will you confess then and cleanse your soul of this sin?

JOAN: Can I be honest with you, Father?

PRIEST: Then you will confess?

JOAN: I wasn't talking about confessing. What I meant was I'd like to talk about my feelings about all this.

PRIEST: All what?

JOAN: This. My trial. My sentence. My execution.

PRIEST: Must we be morbid?

JOAN: It's certainly not my choice. *(She stands and paces.)* But since it has been as they say, thrust upon me, *(To his face)* I'll be as morbid as I have to be to make my point. OK?

PRIEST: *(Backing away a bit)* As you wish.

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JOAN: *(Pacing)* As I wish? I wish I were back in that lovely autumn meadow of my childhood jumping into those big piles of leaves. But since that was then and this is now. . . *(To his face again)* and since I'm about to be barbequed, I'd like to set the record straight. OK?

PRIEST: In the form of a confession?

JOAN: NO! In the form of a protest! A diatribe! A chewing' out! A criticism, if you will.

PRIEST: If you will it.

JOAN: I sure do will it. *(Paces as she talks)* First off, they are not burning me out of any little problem with me dressing up in men's clothes. What a laugh.

PRIEST: This is no laughing matter.

JOAN: No? Watch me. *(She laughs, then seriously)* To continue.

PRIEST: Please do.

JOAN: I do please. I am being burned not for being dressed as a man, but for having the courage to *act* as one. To stand up and fight for what I felt was right, for what was my duty, for what my God would have me do.

PRIEST: You dare assume to know what God thinks?

JOAN: I know a lot of you men who do that and I don't see any of you being barbequed for it. Most of you become saints, if you know what I mean.

PRIEST: I think you assume too much.

JOAN: You might be right. But I know what my heart tells me and is it not through our hearts that God speaks to us? Isn't that what you all say?

PRIEST: Well- you also say God spoke to you in French and not in English.

JOAN: *(She laughs ironically)* I am French. *(She shrugs.)* I guess he figured I'd catch on faster if he spoke my language. Is that a sin?

PRIEST: Well

JOAN: Well, well, well. Confess it. It is a sin to you English, who have captured me.

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PRIEST: *(Whispering)* Not to me. I think

JOAN: Unfortunately, it's not important what we little people think, Father.

PRIEST: I have often heard that.

JOAN: So if you ask me why I am being burned tomorrow, I will tell you. Do you ask?

PRIEST: What?

JOAN: Do you want to know the real reason I am going to be barbequed tomorrow?

PRIEST: I have this strange feeling you will tell me whether or not I wish to hear it.

JOAN: Yes. You are right, Father. You know me well.

PRIEST: (*Whispering to her)* It is an honor. *(Louder)* Then you will confess?

JOAN: (*Whispering)* To God I will. *(Louder)* Is it not your lot in life to hear the final ravings of those of us who are about to be *(Still louder)* barbequed for reasons of state?

PRIEST: (*In a near whisper)* We all have our crosses to bear.

JOAN: We do indeed. Or our flames.

PRIEST: And still you won't confess?

JOAN: You want my confession?

PRIEST: It would lighten both our hearts.

JOAN: (*She sits in chair.)* OK, OK. Here it is. You want to take notes?

PRIEST: That is not necessary. It will be between you, me and God.

JOAN: Yes. And the five guards your king has placed outside my door. I guess they fear the little maid of Orleans more than I thought.

PRIEST: (*Whispering to her)* They do.

JOAN: I guessed as much.

PRIEST: So . . .

JOAN: So I confess I did dress up as a man. But only because they aren't in the habit of making armor for women these days. Maybe some day, but not in the fifteenth century. Also, I confess I did take up arms. I did slay many in

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battle. I did wage war. I did all these things. Although we never fought on Sundays.

PRIEST: I have heard.

JOAN: Sunday is God's day and I did all these things for...*(She stops and thinks.)*

PRIEST: Yes... For whom did you do all these things, Joan?

JOAN: You see. That's the funny thing, Father. I did them for my king, my country and my God. You think I made the right choice?

PRIEST: It is not for me to say.

JOAN: Right. Now everyone is mum. Mum's the word. Let the girl burn. Do not stand up and defend her. Do not be a man. Do not protest too loudly. . . *(In his face)* Or at all.

PRIEST: I am just a priest.

JOAN: I am just a girl.

PRIEST: As you say.

JOAN: What does it matter what I say? Tomorrow I will be barbequed and my ashes will be scattered to the four winds. And that will be that for little Joan of Domremy, France. Right. Father?

PRIEST: One can never tell. God moves in mysterious ways.

JOAN: As you say.

PRIEST: So is that it?

JOAN: Is that what?

PRIEST: Your confession?

JOAN: If you like.

PRIEST: Joan, it's not for me to decide. It's for you to decide.

JOAN: I prefer to sit and wait. I am cold and tired. I just want to get it over with. I just hope everyone has a good time at the barbeque tomorrow. I know I used to love them. Of course, at those we were usually cooking a pig and not a

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person, but then I suppose if you were a pig you were not amused.

PRIEST: I would think not.

JOAN: Me, too. They sure squealed a lot. Guess I will too.

PRIEST: Joan!

JOAN: Sorry, sorry. I just keep thinking about those flames. I'll try to think of those great piles of leaves back home in Domremy, or maybe I'll think of the sunshine tomorrow. I have this feeling it's going to be a glorious day.

PRIEST: As you say.

JOAN: Yes. My heart tells me it will be.

PRIEST: *(The lights dim out and a spotlight comes up on the PRIEST, who walks up front to stand before the audience.)* Then it was all over, the executioner claimed there was nothing left of Joan - nothing at all, except her heart. That, said the executioner, would not burn. *(He shrugs.)* Who's to believe a demented, probably drunken, executioner? *(He smiles, points to himself and whispers to audience.)* Me. *(Lights dim out as the curtain falls.)*

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